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Trade and markets in the economy of the nomadic Fulani of Niger (Bororo)

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Document Type: Essay

Original Page: 349

Culture (OWC): [Fulani \(MS11\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Western Africa

Field Date: 1951

Coverage Date: 1951 AD - 1951 AD

Place Coverage: Tahoua And Zinder Regions, Niger

Section Title(S): Socio-Economic Relations.

This economic role has social aspect, and the particular relationship which joins the Bororo with their *dillalai* takes the form of a "social contract." Those to whom the Bororo of the Tahoua region turn belong to the category *dillalai-mahautaa* or middlemen-butchers. Normally they do not succeed in becoming independent traders (*dioula*), as do certain middlemen of a superior category, who buy in the dry and cold seasons at important markets in the interior in order to resell in Nigeria. Some of these say they are the descendants of captives who belonged to Fulani or Bororo families now in Niger. This fact explains why in the Hausa language of the eastern sector, the word *mahaucii* is synonymous with the word *baringe*, meaning a slave living close to the village of his Fulani master. But if their ancestors were of the butcher caste among the Fulani, today they do not practice this profession and limit themselves to buying and selling. They constitute one of the numerous branches reckoned among the profession of butcher in Hausa society.

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These *dillalai-mahautaa*, although they are today free, continue to observe towards the descendants of their former masters certain of the obligations under which their ancestors lay. The family butcher must feed his master's horse when the latter passes through his village, and the Fulani have kept the custom of having their butchers move with them, as in the times when the latter lived in the master's village. In family life, the settled Fulani rely on them for slaughtering and cutting up the animals at their ceremonies and they pay them in food and kola nuts. Among the Bororo, servile relations have become very much lessened in content and have actually been assimilated into a sort of joking relationship (*dendiraagal*).

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Even within Bororo society this relationship is asymmetrical, the brother's children playing the role of "masters" in relation to the sister's children, called the "slaves." It was natural that this second position be assigned to the *dillali-mahaucii*, who remains the inferior, the subordinate. As cross-cousins they perform reciprocal services. The *dillali* gives food and lodging to "his Bororo" when the latter comes to do business in the village; the latter (the Bororo) receives him in his camp, giving him, from time to time, the gift of a cow (in the *dendiraagal* relationship the gifts given by the superior to the inferior are always the greater). In addition, the *dillali-mahaucii* takes orders for his Bororo clients and brings the goods they need to them  350 in the bush. Both of them indulge in verbal joking, and the "slave" is entitled, like the sister's son, to "rob" his "master" of a head of cattle to sell for his own profit: a simple simulacrum implying restoration under one form or another. No motive for disagreement, say the *dillalai-mahautaa*, can arise between them and "their Bororos." The sole difference of any account between this *dendiraagal* relationship and the relationship that holds between true cross-cousins is the scrupulously observed interdiction on marriage between these groups. This professional "guild" is the only one in Niger to benefit from this situation. In Fouta-Jalon this relationship existed in a parallel form between the sedentary Fulani and the traders whom they protected and whom they called "their *sarakolle*." (Vieillard 1939 : 23, 120). It is to them that the pastoral-agriculturalists turned to sell their cattle or their slaves.

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